



Bill Clinton hugs White House intern Monica Lewinsky the day after his reelection in 1996. The image was later said to be evidence of their relationship.

IN JANUARY, US PRESIDENT BILL CLINTON became the center of a scandal involving his relationship with a former White House intern, **Monica Lewinsky**. Clinton was already implicated in a sexual harassment case and was being investigated by independent counsel Kenneth Starr. The president denied the relationship. In December, he became only the second president in US history to

be **impeached** (Andrew Johnson was the first, in 1868). Clinton was charged with committing perjury in front of a grand jury, but acquitted the following year.

A devastating **earthquake** hit northern **Afghanistan** on February 4. It killed an estimated 4,000 people, and left around 30,000 homeless.

The **Good Friday Agreement** was signed on April 10. It marked a major breakthrough in the Northern Ireland **peace process**. A referendum held in Northern Ireland and the Republic of Ireland on May 22 was overwhelmingly in favour of the accord.

Pol Pot, former Khmer Rouge ruler of Cambodia (see 1978), died on April 15. The Khmer Rouge had deposed him as leader and sentenced him to life imprisonment in 1977.

Eritrean and **Ethiopian** border clashes turned into a full-scale war in May. Both countries, among the poorest in the world, spent millions on sophisticated weaponry.

India and **Pakistan** went nuclear this year. India performed underground nuclear explosions on May 12 near the Pakistani border; Pakistan responded by carrying out its own tests on May 28.

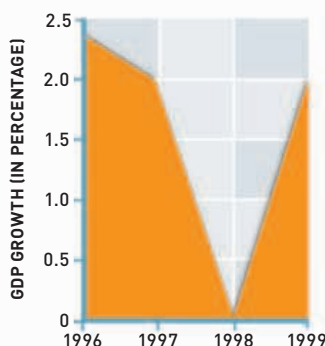
Japan officially entered a **recession** on June 12. It was the first time its economy had shrunk in 12 years. The news caused global stock markets to slump.

US missiles pounded targets in **Afghanistan** and **Sudan** on August 20, in retaliation for the bombing of US Embassies in

Tanzania and Kenya earlier in the month. America said one target was a base for **Osama Bin Laden**, founder of the Islamic extremist organization **al-Qaeda**.

General Pinochet, former Chilean dictator (see 1973), was arrested in London on October 16 by police acting on behalf of Spain, who alleged Pinochet had committed atrocities against Spanish citizens. Pinochet was deemed too ill for extradition and released in 2000.

On May 1, Saddam Hussein wrote an open letter to the UN Security Council threatening "grave consequences" if sanctions against Iraq were not lifted. The attempts by **UN weapons inspectors** to verify the weapons arsenal in Iraq ended on December 16, when the Iraqis refused to co-operate. US and British air strikes on Iraq, known as **Operation Desert Fox**, began hours later.



Recession in Japan

Japan's recession was at its worst in 1998. It was caused by a drop in exports, weak domestic demand, and a fall in property prices.



Police confront demonstrators at the WTO conference in Seattle, northwest US. The protests were against large corporations and globalization.

A SINGLE EUROPEAN CURRENCY, the **Euro**, was launched on January 1. Eleven European Union member states decided to adopt the Euro, which became a full economic currency in 2002.

The international community accused President Slobodan Milosevic of "**ethnic cleansing**" when 45 ethnic Albanians were found dead, apparently executed by Serbs. Kosovo peace talks ended without agreement on February 23 and a week later NATO forces announced they would escalate their **bombardment of Yugoslavia**. The purging of Albanians by Serbian troops increased, and half a million Albanians fled Kosovo. Milosevic agreed to withdraw his troops on June 9, in response to unrelenting NATO bombing.

Thabo Mbeki won the South African presidential elections on June 2, succeeding Nelson Mandela. He faced huge economic and social challenges, including the terrible impact of HIV/AIDS.

East Timor, in Southeast Asia, asked for intervention from international troops after a complete breakdown in law and order in September. This followed a referendum, which voted for independence from Indonesia. Anti-independence Timorese rebels, supported by the Indonesian military, killed an estimated 1,400 Timorese, and 300,000 people fled to neighboring West Timor.

A military coup in **Pakistan** on October 12 brought to power **General Pervez Musharraf**



Solar eclipse

A total solar eclipse occurred on August 11, 1999. It was watched by over 350 million people in Asia and Europe.

(b. 1943), who took the role of "chief executive." The international community condemned the coup and many nations imposed sanctions against Pakistan.

The **World Trade Organization (WTO)** held a **conference** in Seattle, US, late in the year, which was delayed by protesters campaigning for environmental issues and against globalization. Demonstrators clashed with police before being dispersed.

NASA lost contact with its **Mars Polar Lander** shortly before its planned entry into the Martian atmosphere. The failure of the mission was blamed on a software error.

Macau reverted from Portuguese to Chinese rule on December 20, after 442 years of Portuguese control. Macau was the last remaining colonial state in Asia. **Edmond Ho Hau-wah** (b. 1955), a banker, became leader of the new government.

